Three Mistakes Families Make When Everyone Needs to Know What's Going On With Dad

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the simple habit that replaces it.

These three are common in a week like yours. None of them is a failing. They're what happens when a lot of people care about one man and the news is moving fast.

1 Telling the story from scratch to every person who asks

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE You've explained Dad's week to your sister, your aunt, the neighbor and two people at the doctor's office. Each telling comes out a little different, and by Thursday you can't recall who heard which part.

WHY IT HAPPENS Everyone who asks cares about Dad, and answering each of them feels like the least you can do. Nobody expected the story to need telling this many times.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write it once: what happened, who is involved, which decision comes next, and what you still don't know. Read or send the same page to everyone who asks. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that email can keep even relatives who aren't nearby up to date. [1]

2 Working from scattered notes

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The nurse's name is in a voicemail. The appointment is in your sister's texts. A date somebody mentioned is on the back of an envelope, and the rest is in your head.

WHY IT HAPPENS Each note made sense where you put it, in the minute you had. Nobody sets up a filing system in the middle of a week like this one.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Pick one place, a notebook or a single shared document, and copy everything into it with the date and who said it. Medicare's discharge checklist asks patients and their caregivers to write down names, phone numbers and the dates and times of upcoming appointments. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention gives “keep important caregiving information in one place” as a reason for having a written care plan. [2] [3]

3 Assuming someone else is handling an important task

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Your brother thinks you called the pharmacy. You think he did. Everyone is fairly sure the follow-up appointment was made, and nobody can say by whom.

WHY IT HAPPENS In a hurry, families assume, and it runs in every direction. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that siblings may assume the one who is helping has everything covered, and that families often don't think through who takes which role. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** List the tasks and put a name beside each one, then make the two or three calls that confirm it. Where there's no name, write “nobody yet.” That's a question for the family, not a fault in anyone. The Alliance's advice for family meetings applies here too: make sure each person understands what he or she has agreed to do. [1]

The one habit behind all three

One page, kept in one place, with a name beside every task and “not yet known” wherever you'd otherwise guess.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what Dad's situation means or what your family should decide. It names three habits, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step, and a better one for each.

Ready for the next step?

You know the three habits that keep the story scattered, and what replaces each. The care interview goes further than one page can: it walks through Dad's living arrangement, his typical day and each area of daily life, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The remarks about email, written names and dates, one place for caregiving information and what each person has agreed to do come from the sources below. The CDC's care plan is a different document from a family's own page. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Your discharge planning checklist
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings

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